

GETTING ORGANIZED

GOALS OF THIS EXERCISE

1. Maintain a program of recovery free from addiction and the negative effects of Attention-Deficit Disorder (ADD).
2. Structure a recovery program sufficient to maintain abstinence and to reduce the negative effects of ADD on learning and self-esteem.
3. Learn to tune in to physical signs that indicate drifting of attention.
4. Identify coping strategies that have worked to sustain attention in the past.
5. Develop new skills to cope with inattention and difficulties with concentration.

ADDITIONAL HOMEWORK THAT CAN BE APPLICABLE TO CLIENTS WHO EXPERIENCE PROBLEMS WITH ATTENTION-DEFICIT DISORDER, INATTENTIVE TYPE

- A Different Approach
- Analyzing Acting-Out Behavior
- From Recklessness to Calculated Risks
- Interest and Skill Self-Assessment
- Negotiating Skills for Success
- Working toward Independence

ADDITIONAL PROBLEMS FOR WHICH THIS EXERCISE MAY BE USEFUL

- Attention-Deficit/Hyperactivity Disorder (ADHD)
- Psychosis

SUGGESTIONS FOR PROCESSING THIS EXERCISE WITH THE CLIENT

The “Getting Organized” activity is intended for the client who struggles with inattention, distractibility, or difficulty completing tasks related to ADD or ADHD. It can be used with other clients who generally need assistance getting organized. Follow-up can include having the client keep a journal or log of distractions or instances of inattention and then self-monitor improvement through the use of newly learned skills. It is important to reinforce small successes in order to create and sustain therapeutic momentum and build further successes. This exercise can be useful for parents coping with ADD-like symptoms in their children, as well as for clients

who struggle with symptoms of ADD.

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Managing the daily events of life is a major concern in recovery. Addictive lifestyles interfere with being organized, and people who experience symptoms like those of Attention-Deficit Disorder (ADD) often struggle with the same things. There can be many reasons we forget to do things or don't complete tasks. We may get distracted, get tired, lose focus or interest, jump from task to task, procrastinate, or lack confidence. Finishing any task successfully involves four steps: (1) determining what you need to do, (2) recognizing cues that your focus is slipping, (3) using tools and techniques to help you stay focused, and (4) checking your progress and rewarding yourself. By doing this, you have a better chance of finishing what you start, which will help your self-confidence and make it easier to start the next task. This exercise will help you identify barriers to getting organized and finishing tasks, and provide coping strategies for you to practice.

1. For the next week, please monitor the following items and write what you learn below.

- a. What tasks do you have difficulty completing?

- b. Where do the breakdowns seem to occur (i.e., time of day, after a certain length of time)? Please be specific.

- c. What gets in the way of getting organized and completing tasks (i.e., not enough time, boredom, too many distractions)? Please be specific.

What body cues (physical signs) tell you that your ability to focus is decreasing?

- d. What tasks can you usually complete, whether they're difficult or not?

e. What has helped you so far in getting organized and completing what you set out to do (e.g., frequent reminders, no distractions, notes to yourself)?

2. Please choose one task you have difficulty completing. It's helpful to pick one that you have to do often, so you can have many opportunities to practice (e.g., laundry, shopping, homework). Write it here. _____

3. Please document every time you successfully completed this task and how you did it. If you found a method that worked for this, you can use it for other tasks, as well as trying the other following methods.

Coping Strategy Suggestion 1. Break the activity into smaller segments, either shorter time segments (e.g., 15-minute intervals) or smaller steps (e.g., get to the bank, get quarters, sort clothes, etc., versus do laundry today). This makes it easier to pay attention.

a. Please write a plan for how you can use this strategy for your activity.

b. What reward will you give yourself when you complete each task?

Coping Strategy Suggestion 2. Use concrete, visible reminders of deadlines. You can do this by writing lists, using a calendar, and using a planner to set daily goals. Don't over commit yourself! That can increase stress and fatigue, which make ADD symptoms worse, and could prevent you from finishing what you started.

a. Please write a plan for how you will use this strategy for your activity.

b. What reward will you give yourself and when?

Coping Strategy Suggestion 3. Set yourself up for success. You can do this by starting with tasks you know you can complete. Doing those tasks first will increase your motivation to follow through on more difficult ones. Or you may want to work on tougher tasks first while you're focused and fresh—whichever works best for you.

a. Please write a plan for how you can use this strategy for your activity.

b. What will your reward be, and when?

Coping Strategy Suggestion 4. Develop a written daily and weekly routine and stick to it. Creating a routine that includes daily tasks, meals, sleep/wake, medications, accomplishments for the day (e.g., pay bills, do laundry) and time for relaxation and fun is helpful in managing time and improves your chances of accomplishing the things you need to do. When our lives get busy and there are more demands on our time, adding new things to our existing schedules helps us stay organized and not neglect these necessary daily tasks.

a. Please write a simple plan for how you can use this strategy this week.

b. What will your reward be at the end of each day and the end of the week?

Set a starting date and begin with strategy suggestion 1. Evaluate your success, struggles, and lessons learned after you've practiced it. Please record the results here.

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Be sure to bring this handout with you to your next session with your therapist, and be prepared to discuss your thoughts and feelings about this exercise.